

The Worst Redesigns in DC History

Skinny Lobo

([https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Lobo_I_\(Prime_Earth\)](https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Lobo_I_(Prime_Earth)))

You can get panels of this version here:

<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Justice-League/Issue-23-2?id=18467>

<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Lobo-2014/Issue-1?id=32108>

<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Lobo-2014/Issue-2?id=32113>)

Skinny Lobo.

New 52 Lobo is the absolute gold standard for what happens when a boardroom of executives tries to make a parody character "sexy" for a demographic that doesn't actually exist.

For decades, we knew Lobo ([https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Lobo_\(New_Earth\)](https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Lobo_(New_Earth))) as the Main Man, a giant, pale-skinned Czarnian **who looked like he'd been kicked out of a KISS** ([https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Kiss_\(band\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Kiss_(band))) **tribute band for being too rowdy.**

This guy was one of the characters that I just can't help but love because he was a hulking mass of muscle, spiked leather, and dreadlocks, usually surrounded by a cloud of cigar smoke and the screams of his bounties.

Then 2011 rolled around, and DC decided that this heavy-metal space biker was a "crude impostor." ([https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Lobo_II_\(Prime_Earth\)](https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Lobo_II_(Prime_Earth)))

In Justice League #23.2 (https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Justice_League_Vol_2_23.2:_Lobo), they introduced the "real" Lobo, **who looked less like an intergalactic mercenary and more like a rejected member of a K-pop boy band who spends too much on hair gel.**

This new version was slender, polished, and had the kind of chiseled jawline usually reserved for CW actors playing sensitive vampires.

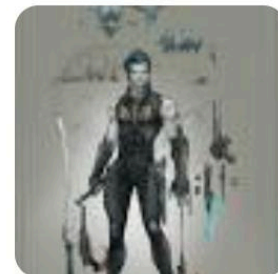
Gone were the chains and the meat hooks, replaced by glowing blue lines and futuristic energy blades **that I think looked like they belonged in a high-end kitchen appliance catalog.**

Fans immediately started calling him "Twilight Lobo" or "Faux-bo," and honestly, the insults were well-deserved.

 www.comicsbeat.com

Lobo goes Twilight with new look

23 Aug 2013



(Twilight Lobo)

What I think makes it even worse is that the original Lobo was created specifically to make fun of the gritty, over-the-top anti-heroes of the 90s.

So by turning him into a sleek, brooding "pretty boy," DC unironically became the very thing they were originally satirizing.

It's like taking a parody of a fast-food mascot and turning it into a professional fitness model; you've completely missed the point of why people liked the character in the first place. On top of that, he lacked any of the charm or chaotic energy that made the original a cult favorite.

Instead of a guy who would blow up a planet because someone looked at him funny, we got a guy who looked like he would write a very long, very sad poem about how hard it is to be so handsome and deadly at the same time.

The visual personality was stripped away and replaced with a generic, high-tech athletic suit that to me felt incredibly corporate and soulless.

It's pretty clear to me that this is one of those classic cases of fixing something that wasn't broken and ending up with a pile of stylish garbage.

Thankfully, DC eventually realized that nobody wants a polite Lobo, **and they tossed this version into the cosmic dumpster where he belongs.**

Edgy Harley Quinn

[https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Harleen_Quinzel_\(Prime_Earth\)](https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Harleen_Quinzel_(Prime_Earth))
<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Suicide-Squad/Issue-1?id=16968>
<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Suicide-Squad/Issue-2?id=16992>
<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Harley-Quinn-2014/Issue-0?id=14680>

Edgy Harley Quinn.

Prepare yourself for the visual equivalent of a mid-life crisis at a rave, because New 52

Harley Quinn is a masterclass in trying way too hard to be edgy.

Harley started her life in the animated series as a jester

[https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Harleen_Quinzel_\(New_Earth\)](https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Harleen_Quinzel_(New_Earth))), wearing a simple red-and-black suit that told you everything you needed to know about her: she was funny, she was dangerous, and she was obsessed with a clown.

When the New 52 reboot hit in Suicide Squad Vol. 4 #1

https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Suicide_Squad_Vol_4_1), DC decided the jester look was too "childish" and replaced it with something that looks like it was assembled during a 3:00 AM shopping spree at a discount goth warehouse.

But what made me hate it even more is the fact that her new origin involved being shoved into a vat of acid, which bleached her skin permanently, **because apparently, having a choice in her own aesthetic was too much character agency for the 2011 editorial team.**





(Getting her skin bleached permanently

<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Suicide-Squad/Issue-7?id=17036>)

The new outfit was a mess of plunging corsets, tiny two-toned hot pants, and enough belts to keep a cargo ship anchored in a hurricane.

First off, the practicalities of fighting crime, **or committing it**, in a corset and thigh-high stockings are non-existent.

On top of that, the color scheme shifted to a chaotic red and blue **that made her look like a patriotic popsicle that had been dropped on a dirty sidewalk.**

Even worse is the sheer amount of unnecessary "stuff" glued to her body, from spiked collars to random straps that serve no purpose other than to make her look "extreme."

It felt like a desperate attempt to appeal to the "male gaze" while simultaneously trying to capture a punk-rock aesthetic, **and if you ask me, I'm gonna say it failed at both.**

The original jester suit was iconic because it was thematic; it linked her to the harlequin tradition and her psychological obsession with Joker.

Meanwhile, the New 52 version just looked like a generic "crazy girl" trope that you'd see in a low-budget action movie.

While the split-colored pigtails actually stuck around and became part of her movie look, I think the rest of this outfit was a visual headache that prioritized sex appeal over actual character design.

It's the kind of redesign that screams **"we want teenagers to buy posters"** rather than "we want to tell a good story."

By stripping away the whimsical nature of her original look, they turned a unique character into a noisy, over-sexualized caricature that lost its heart.

Non-chubby Amanda Waller

[https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Amanda_Waller_\(Prime_Earth\)](https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Amanda_Waller_(Prime_Earth))

<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Suicide-Squad-Amanda-Waller/Full?id=104479>)

Non-chubby Amanda Waller.

Imagine taking one of the most intimidating, powerful women in government and deciding that what she really needs is a gym membership and a complete facial reconstruction, because that's exactly what happened to New 52 Amanda Waller.

For years, Amanda Waller ([https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Amanda_Waller_\(New_Earth\)](https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Amanda_Waller_(New_Earth))) was known as "The Wall," a name she earned by being a stern, middle-aged, heavy-set Black woman who could make Batman nervous just by squinting at him.

She was a villain that I genuinely despised because she didn't need to be a ninja or have superpowers; her power came from the fact that she was the smartest, most ruthless person in the room, which actually made her one of the best-written villains I've ever seen.

Then, Suicide Squad Vol. 4 #1

(<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Suicide-Squad/Issue-1?id=16968>) arrived, and suddenly Waller looked like she was auditioning for a lead role in a superhero soap opera.

This new version was young, thin, and conventionally attractive, trading her sensible business suits for form-fitting tactical gear and high heels.

For me, it was a baffling decision that completely erased the visual metaphor of her character, and here's why.

Firstly, making her a physical combatant who does backflips and shoots guns completely misses why she was scary in the first place.

Not only that, it removed one of the very few examples of body diversity in mainstream comics, replacing a unique and formidable silhouette with a generic "sexy spy" template.

But what made it ten times worse is that the editorial team seemingly thought that "authority" could only be represented by someone who looks like a supermodel.

That's because her original design told a story of a woman who clawed her way to the top through sheer intellect and iron will.

But the New 52 version **looked like she just finished a yoga class and decided to run a secret government death squad on her way home.**

I genuinely think it was a shallow transformation that felt like a slap in the face to fans who appreciated her as a grounded, realistic figure of power.

As expected, the backlash was immediate and loud, mostly because everyone realized that a skinny, gymnastic Waller is just much less interesting than a formidable, immovable bureaucrat.

You don't call someone "The Wall" because they're sleek and aerodynamic; you call them that because they're the thing that stops you in your tracks.

DC eventually realized their mistake and brought back the classic look, acknowledging that you can't replace gravitas with a low-carb diet.

It turns out that being a terrifying political mastermind is a lot more impressive **when you don't look like you're about to sell me a subscription to a luxury fitness app.**

Drake

([https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Timothy_Drake_\(Prime_Earth\)](https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Timothy_Drake_(Prime_Earth)))

<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Young-Justice-2019/Issue-10?id=163394>

<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Young-Justice-2019/Issue-12?id=165987>

<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Young-Justice-2019/Issue-13?id=167271>)

Drake.

There is a very specific type of secondary-embarrassment you feel when a genius detective decides to name himself after a male duck, and that feeling is the entire legacy of Tim Drake becoming "Drake."

Tim has always been the smart one of the Robins, the kid who figured out Batman's secret identity through sheer detective work.

I like Dick Grayson ([https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Richard_Grayson_\(Prime_Earth\)\)](https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Richard_Grayson_(Prime_Earth))) better, but I don't mind him. He's still not as annoying as Damian.

([https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Damian_Wayne_\(Prime_Earth\)\)](https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Damian_Wayne_(Prime_Earth)))

Personally, he had a great run as Red Robin, where he finally got a cool, bird-themed costume that felt like a natural evolution.

But then, in the 2019 Young Justice run

(https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Young_Justice_Vol_3_10), someone decided that Tim needed to be "edgy" in the most boring way possible.

That's when he ditched the red and black for a muddy, poop-colored brown bodysuit with dull yellow accents.

My problem with that is: brown is not a superhero color; it's the color of a delivery truck or a very old potato.

My other problem was that the suit lacked a cape, which left him looking like an uninspired tactical plumber who had lost his way to a job site.

But the real kicker, the thing that I think makes this a legendary failure, is the name.

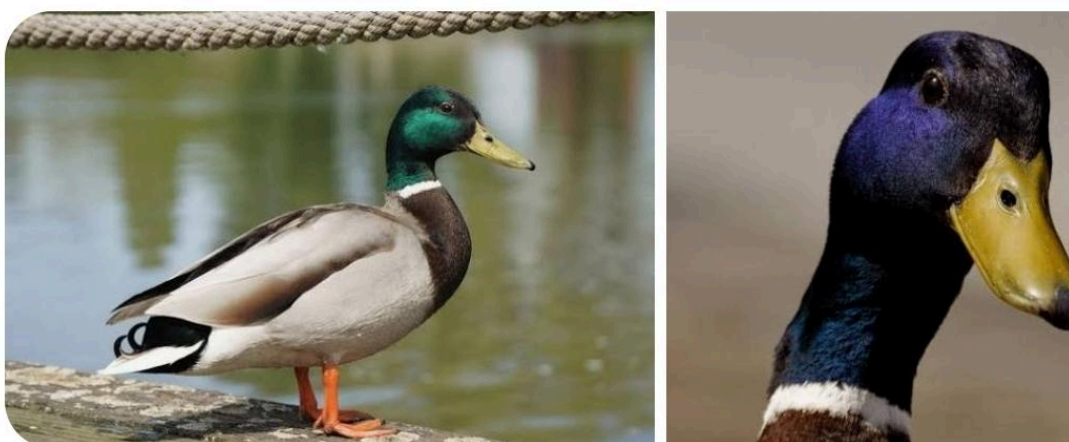
He chose to call himself "Drake," like someone used to call him on his cellphone... late night when they needed his love. (Play a short clip of this song, specifically at the "you used to call me on my cell phone" part https://youtu.be/uxpDa-c-4Mc?si=6v5oEbFF_6MsZV_K)

What makes it even crazier is that "Drake" is his actual last name.

This is a kid trained by the world's greatest detective to protect his secret identity at all costs, and his brilliant idea was to just tell everyone his surname whenever he fights crime.

It's like Bruce Wayne fighting crime under the name "The Wayne" or Clark Kent calling himself "Kent."

To justify this, the comic tried to claim that a "drake" is one of the most dangerous birds in existence, which is hilarious because I looked it up and a drake is literally just a male duck.



A drake is a **fully sexually matured male duck of any species**. Drakes are distinguished from female ducks (hens) by their vibrant plumage, a distinct "drake feather" (a curled feather on their tail), and a quieter, raspy call compared to the loud quack of a female. They are often heavier and more colorful, especially during mating season.  YouTube +4

(Drake meaning male duck)

That's why every time he showed up on the page, I wasn't thinking about a dangerous predator; **I was thinking about a mallard in a brown jumpsuit.**

I get that the redesign was trying to be "street-level" and "grounded," **but it just ended up being visually bland and logically bankrupt.**

It's a design that says **"I've given up on being a hero and I'm now focusing on my career in mid-tier logistics management."**

Thankfully, the "Drake" era didn't last long, as everyone involved realized that being named after a duck while wearing the colors of a cardboard box wasn't exactly the legacy Tim deserved.

Personally, if you're going to blow your secret identity for a cool nickname, **maybe pick one that doesn't make people want to throw bread crumbs at you in the park.**

Renegade Hal Jordan

[https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Green_Lantern_\(Hal_Jordan\)#Renegade](https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Green_Lantern_(Hal_Jordan)#Renegade)

<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Green-Lantern-2011/Issue-41?id=5079>
<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Green-Lantern-2011/Issue-42?id=5080>
<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Green-Lantern-2011/Issue-43?id=5161>

Renegade Hal Jordan.

If you've ever wondered what it would look like if a superhero had a mental breakdown and decided to join a 90s garage band, look no further than Renegade Hal Jordan.

Hal ([https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Hal_Jordan_\(New_Earth\)](https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Hal_Jordan_(New_Earth))) is usually the ultimate "straight arrow" of the DC Universe, a test pilot who loves his uniform and his glowing green ring. But in 2015, DC decided he needed to go rogue to save the reputation of the Green Lantern Corps, **which apparently required him to stop showering and buy a very large coat.**

The "Renegade" look featured Hal with long, greasy hair and a tattered green trench coat worn over a raggedy version of his flight suit.

It might seem pretty normal but here's why I'm not a fan of it.

First, the trench coat trope was already ten years out of date by the time this story was published.

Second, he ditched his power ring for a bulky, glowing gauntlet that looked like a prototype laser tag toy from a thrift store.



(Gauntlet <https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Green-Lantern-2011/Issue-41?id=5079>)

But the worst of all is that he started flying around in a rusty old spaceship instead of just using his own powers.





(Piloting spaceship <https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Green-Lantern-2011/Issue-41?id=5079>)

For me, this was a complete rejection of everything that makes Green Lantern visually interesting.

The clean lines and glowing constructs were replaced by a messy, "drifter" aesthetic that felt incredibly forced.

It's like the editorial team looked at a picture of a 90s anti-hero and said, "Yes, let's do that, but fifteen years too late."

That's why I think this whole era felt like Hal was going through a very expensive, very public mid-life crisis where he tried to convince everyone he was "edgy" now.

Instead of an elite space cop, we got a guy who looked like he spent his weekends hanging out at a dive bar complaining about his ex-boss.

The gauntlet was clunky and lacked the elegance of the ring, and the long hair just made him look like he'd lost his comb in a black hole.

It was a style-over-substance gimmick that failed because it fundamentally misunderstood who Hal Jordan is.

Because you and I know he's not a brooding loner; he's a guy who thrives on structure and confidence.

Turning him into a tattered fugitive in a trench coat just made him look like a background character from an unsuccessful sci-fi pilot.

Luckily, **he eventually remembered where the barbershop was and went back to his classic look, leaving the trench coat to the people who actually know how to wear them.**

Flashpoint Zatanna

([https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Zatanna_Zatara_\(Flashpoint_Timeline\)](https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Zatanna_Zatara_(Flashpoint_Timeline)))

<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Flashpoint-Secret-Seven/Issue-2?id=91566> page 28

<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Flashpoint-Secret-Seven/Issue-3?id=91567>)

Flashpoint Zatanna.

Zatanna Zatara is a character who has one of the most perfect, recognizable costumes in comics, **so naturally, someone decided to ruin it by making her look like she works at a gas station.**

Her classic ([https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Zatanna_Zatara_\(New_Earth\)](https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Zatanna_Zatara_(New_Earth))) stage-magician look is probably the best costume design that I've ever laid my eyes on.

The top hat, the tuxedo, the fishnets, these are a brilliant piece of design that perfectly reflects her heritage and her powers.

It's theatrical, it's fun, and it stands out in a crowd of spandex.

But during the Flashpoint (https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Flash:_Flashpoint) event, we got an alternate-reality Zatanna who was stripped of all that personality.

Instead of a magical performer, she was turned into a generic biker girl wearing a red and black leather jacket and plain jeans.

This felt so out of place because there is absolutely nothing about this outfit that says "I can rewrite reality by speaking backwards."

To make it worse, she was given heavy, smeared eyeliner to make sure we all knew she was very sad and very serious.

But the craziest part is that she rode a motorcycle instead of, **you know, using magic to fly or teleport.**

I think this was a complete visual lobotomy of the character.

By removing the theatrical flair, the designers turned one of DC's most vibrant heroes into a forgettable background extra.

The biker aesthetic is the ultimate lazy shorthand for "this character is tough now," but for Zatanna, I gotta say it just made her look boring.

Because there's no mystery or wonder in a leather jacket and combat boots.

It felt like they were trying to ground her for a "gritty" universe, but in doing so, they took away the very thing that makes her special.

Without the top hat and the tuxedo, she's just another person in a jacket **who might be good at fixing an engine** but probably isn't going to save the world from a demon invasion.

It's a design that lacks any imagination, trading iconic imagery for a look that you could find in any bargain bin clothing store.

The Flashpoint universe was supposed to be a dark reflection of our own, but I'll keep it real, making Zatanna look like a bored teenager at a rock concert was just a step too far.

Comment down below if you're a Zatanna fan and this version of hers feels disrespectful to you.

The Dark Knight Strikes Again Flash

([https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Barry_Allen_\(Earth-31\)](https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Barry_Allen_(Earth-31)))

<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Batman-The-Dark-Knight-Strikes-Again/Issue-1> page 50

<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Batman-The-Dark-Knight-Strikes-Again/Issue-2?id=19991> page 71

<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Dark-Knight-III-The-Master-Race/Issue-4?id=47685> page 28)

The Dark Knight Strikes Again Flash.

If you ever wanted to see the Flash look like he's about to participate in a very budget-conscious charity bicycle race, then Frank Miller's redesign in The Dark Knight Strikes Again (https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/The_Dark_Knight_Strikes_Again_Vol_1_1) is for you.

Barry Allen ([https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Barry_Allen_\(New_Earth\)](https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Barry_Allen_(New_Earth))) usually has a costume that is the pinnacle of aerodynamic efficiency, but Miller decided that what the Scarlet Speedster really needed was a pair of skin-tight bicycle shorts.

In this dystopian future story, Barry is rescued from a giant treadmill and put back into action wearing a black long-sleeved shirt with a messy red bolt and, **most tragically, those bare-legged shorts.**

Let's start off by getting the elephant out of the room.

Seeing the Flash's hairy legs while he runs at the speed of light is a visual choice that nobody asked for.

Not only that, he was given clunky, oversized yellow sneakers that looked like they were made of rubber.

And worst of all, as much as I love Frank Miller, his art style in this book was so blocky and distorted that Barry looked less like a speedster and more like a confused refrigerator wearing gym clothes.

The Flash is supposed to represent flow and kinetic energy, but this design made him look heavy, awkward, and deeply uncomfortable.

Meanwhile the black and red color scheme felt muddy and lacked the vibrant "heroic" pop of his traditional suit.

There's no grace to it, no sense of speed, just a guy in mismatched athletic wear who looks like he's forgotten his pants.

I think it's safe to say that it's widely considered one of the worst designs in the history of the character, mainly because it contradicts everything the Flash stands for visually.

Instead of a legendary hero making a triumphant return, he looked like a guy who had been caught mid-workout during a home invasion.

The bare legs and heavy shoes were a functional nightmare that made the fastest man alive **look like he'd be tripped up by a slightly uneven sidewalk.**

Honestly, it's a testament to the fact that even legendary creators can occasionally have an absolute "what were they thinking" moment.

You know a costume is a failure when the most heroic thing about it is the fact that the character is brave enough to wear it in public.

Warrior Guy Gardner

([https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Guy_Gardner_\(New_Earth\)#Warrior](https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Guy_Gardner_(New_Earth)#Warrior))

<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Guy-Gardner-Warrior/Issue-0?id=68305>
<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Guy-Gardner-Warrior/Issue-18?id=68310>
<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Guy-Gardner-Warrior/Issue-19?id=68313>

Warrior Guy Gardner.

Guy Gardner is famous for being the most annoying Green Lantern ([https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Guy_Gardner_\(New_Earth\)](https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Guy_Gardner_(New_Earth))), but his "Warrior" phase took that annoyance and turned it into a grotesque alien nightmare that nobody wanted to see. In the 90s, Guy lost his ring and discovered he had "Vuldarian" (<https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Vuldarians>) DNA, which gave him the power to turn his body into living weapons. Naturally, this meant he had to ditch his classic green bowl-cut look for a shirtless aesthetic covered in glowing purple tribal tattoos, **what could go wrong with that?** But here's the thing: tribal tattoos on a guy from Baltimore is a choice that has aged about as well as a carton of milk in the sun. Not to mention, he could sprout giant, fleshy cannons and maces out of his arms, which looked less like a superpower and more like a very aggressive skin condition.



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THE BEGINNING OF TOMORROW!

GUY GARDNER

WARRIOR



APPROVED
BY THE
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(Weapons on his arms

<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Guy-Gardner-Warrior/Issue-0?id=68305>)

But perhaps the most tragic thing is that he lost all the blue-collar, "tough guy" charm that made him a fan favorite.

Instead of a brawler who used his willpower to punch things, he became a chaotic shapeshifter who looked like a rejected villain from a Saturday morning cartoon.

The design was a transparent attempt to make Guy "extreme" to keep up with characters like Spawn (https://imagecomics.fandom.com/wiki/Albert_Simmons) or Venom ([https://marvel.fandom.com/wiki/Venom_\(Symbiote\)_ \(Earth-616\)](https://marvel.fandom.com/wiki/Venom_(Symbiote)_ (Earth-616))), but I think it just felt desperate and clunky.

It was a complete rejection of his history as a Lantern, turning a grounded character into a bizarre alien freak.

It's the ultimate example of 90s excess, **where more spikes and more tattoos were seen as a substitute for actual character development.**

Guy Gardner: Warrior was an era where the character essentially became a parody of himself, losing the heart of what made him fun in a sea of glowing ink and arm-cannons. Thankfully, DC eventually realized that Guy is much better as a jerk with a ring than a shirtless alien with a cannon for a hand.

It's a good thing they fixed it, **because there's only so much "extreme" tribal body art a reader can handle before they start rooting for the villains.**

Thanoseid

[https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Thanoseid_\(Amalgam_Universe\)](https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Thanoseid_(Amalgam_Universe))

<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Bullets-and-Bracelets/Full?id=121088>

<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Thorion-of-the-New-Asgods/Full?id=127198>)

Thanoseid.

Combining two of the greatest villains in comic history sounds like a foolproof plan, but Thanoseid proved that sometimes, **one plus one equals a very ugly zero.**

During the Amalgam crossover (https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Amalgam_Universe), Marvel's Thanos ([https://marvel.fandom.com/wiki/Thanos_\(Earth-616\)](https://marvel.fandom.com/wiki/Thanos_(Earth-616))) and DC's Darkseid ([https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Darkseid_\(New_Earth\)](https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Darkseid_(New_Earth))) were smashed together to create the ultimate cosmic threat.

You'd think the result would be terrifying, but instead, we got a character **that looked like a bloated Thanos wearing his dad's old armor.**

He had the purple skin and chin of Thanos, but with a rocky texture that was supposed to represent Darkseid.

So why is this bad? Well, I think the design was incredibly clunky and lacked the sleek, minimalist menace of the original characters.

Also, he was given an oversized, blocky helmet that made his head look like a purple toaster.

But even worse is that he lost the regal dignity of Thanos and the stoic power of Darkseid, becoming a visually confused mess of armor plates and glowing energy bits.

I think both original villains are iconic because of their simple, powerful silhouettes.

Thanoseid, on the other hand, was the definition of overdesigned.

He looked like an off-brand action figure you'd find at a pharmacy, **the kind where the colors don't quite match the box art.**

Instead of a universe-shaking threat, he looked like a guy who was struggling to move in a very heavy, very uncomfortable Halloween costume.

It's a classic example of "more is less."

By trying to include every visual element from both characters, the designers ended up with a muddy, uninspired hybrid that failed to capture the essence of either.

It turns out that you can't just slap a ridged chin on a stone face and expect people to be intimidated.

Black Costume Superman

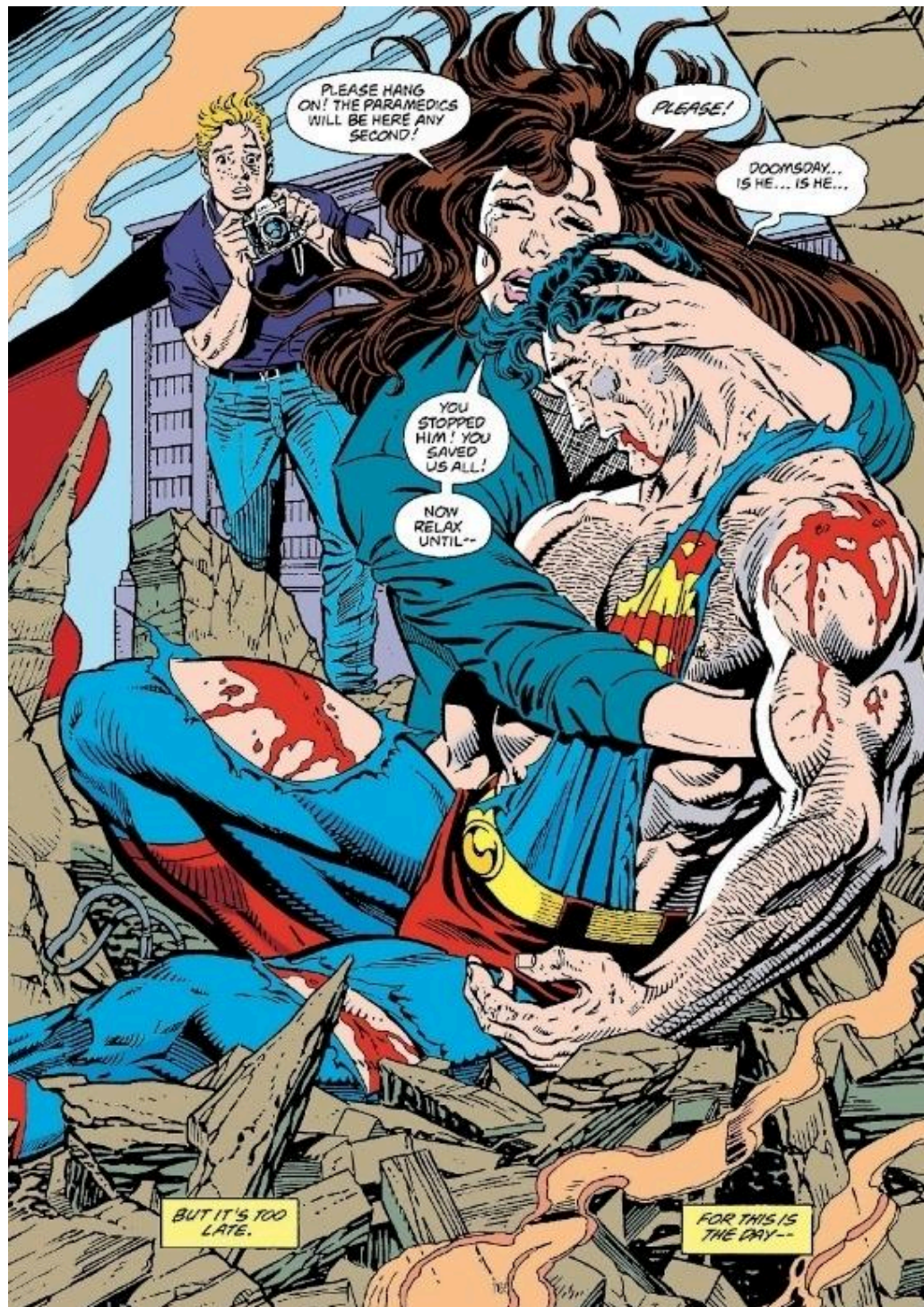
[https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Kal-El_\(New_Earth\)#Death_and_Return_of_Superman](https://dc.fandom.com/wiki/Kal-El_(New_Earth)#Death_and_Return_of_Superman)

<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Superman-1987/Issue-81?id=16744>

<https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Superman-1987/Issue-82?id=16745>

Black Costume Superman.

When Superman came back from the dead in the 90s, he decided to celebrate his resurrection by growing a mullet and carrying a bunch of giant guns, which is exactly as cool as it sounds, meaning it wasn't cool at all.



(Death of Superman <https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Superman-1987/Issue-75?id=16737>)

He emerged from a regeneration matrix wearing a sleek black and silver suit, which, on its own, I think was actually pretty decent.

However, the editorial team decided that "Return of Superman" also meant "Return of the 1980s Hair Trends."

So seeing the Man of Steel with a flowing, greasy mullet was a shock that the world was not prepared for.

And because his powers were still recharging, he spent a good chunk of his comeback carrying massive, cable-covered laser cannons that looked like they were designed by a teenager who really liked Rambo.



(With guns <https://readcomiconline.li/Comic/Superman-1987/Issue-82?id=16745>)

Legend by the way.

But what I despise the most about this design is how much this look contradicted Superman's entire identity as a symbol of hope and light.

By putting him in black, giving him a bad haircut, and handing him firearms, DC was desperately trying to make him fit into the "gritty" 90s anti-hero mold occupied by characters like Punisher ([https://marvel.fandom.com/wiki/Francis_Castle_\(Earth-616\)](https://marvel.fandom.com/wiki/Francis_Castle_(Earth-616))) or Cable ([https://marvel.fandom.com/wiki/Nathan_Summers_\(Earth-616\)](https://marvel.fandom.com/wiki/Nathan_Summers_(Earth-616))).

It felt completely out of character for the world's most optimistic hero to be walking around looking like a roadie for a hair-metal band who had just discovered the joys of heavy weaponry.

The mullet specifically became an instant punchline, a visual reminder of a time when comics were trying way too hard to be "grown-up" by being as cynical as possible. While the black suit itself has been used effectively in later stories as a "recovery suit," the combination of the hair and the guns remains a legendary aesthetic blunder.

I believe everyone can agree that Superman doesn't need a mullet to be tough, and he certainly doesn't need a gun to be effective; his power comes from his character, not his arsenal.

Thankfully, the hair eventually got trimmed, the guns were put away, and Clark went back to the primary colors that actually suit him.

Outro

That's it for this one!

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Cheers, and see you in the next one!